

The aid year opens *October 1.*

What the FAFSA, the CSS Profile, and the Cal Grant each ask for, when every piece of it is due, and how to read the offer that comes *back*.

ONE / WHAT FINANCIAL AID IS

Three kinds of money, three different *gatekeepers*.

Financial aid is not one thing. It is three separate systems, run by different people, decided on different evidence, and opened by different forms. A family that treats it as one thing usually misses one of them.

A college publishes a sticker price, and very few families at a private college pay it. The number that matters is the net price: the full cost of a year minus the grants and scholarships that never have to be repaid. Aid comes in three types, and only one of them lowers that number. Grants and scholarships are money the family keeps. Work-study is money the student earns by working a campus job during the year, and it arrives as a paycheck. Loans are money the family repays with interest after graduation. A loan printed on an aid offer is a bill, not a gift.

Who decides the amount depends on which kind of aid it is. Federal aid runs on a formula Congress wrote, and the FAFSA feeds it. Institutional aid comes out of a college's own budget, and each college sets its own rules, which is why two schools with nearly identical sticker prices can offer the same family very different amounts. Merit aid is not about family finances at all. It is a college spending its own money to attract a student it wants.

KIND OF AID	WHO DECIDES	WHAT IT TURNS ON	WHAT YOU FILE
Federal need-based PELL, WORK-STUDY, DIRECT LOANS	The U.S. Department of Education	2025 income and tax information for every contributor.	FAFSA
Institutional need-based THE COLLEGE'S OWN GRANT	The college's financial aid office	The college's own reading of the family's finances, often including home equity and a noncustodial parent.	CSS Profile or the college's own form, plus the FAFSA
Merit SCHOLARSHIPS	The college's admission office	The strength of the application.	Usually nothing extra. Sometimes an earlier deadline or a separate application.

THE EXPENSIVE MISTAKE Aid is not a discount negotiated at the end. Nearly all of it is decided by forms filed between October and February, and a college is under no obligation to consider a late one.

COST OF ATTENDANCE The college's published estimate of one year: tuition, fees, housing, food, books, and travel.

SAI Student Aid Index. The number the FAFSA produces from a family's finances.

NEED Cost of attendance minus the SAI. A calculated figure, not a judgment about the family.

NET PRICE Cost of attendance minus grants and scholarships. The number that decides what a college costs.

CONTRIBUTOR Anyone required to give information on the FAFSA: the student, a parent, and sometimes a parent's spouse.

TWO / THE FAFSA

One form, and everyone who has to *sign it.*

The Free Application for Federal Student Aid opens on October 1, 2026 for the 2027–28 school year. It is free, it is required for every federal dollar, and most colleges want it before they will award any of their own money.

What it asks for.

The 2027–28 FAFSA uses **2025** tax information. That year is already closed, so nothing done this fall changes what the form sees. Income and tax data are pulled straight from the IRS rather than typed in by hand, which is why the consent step below is not optional.

Who counts as a contributor.

A contributor is anyone required to provide information on the form: the student, the student's spouse if married, a biological or adoptive parent, and in some cases that parent's spouse. Being a contributor does not make anyone financially responsible for the bill. But if a required contributor declines to provide information and consent, the form is incomplete and the student receives no federal aid at all.

- **Every contributor needs their own StudentAid.gov account**, with their own username and password, sometimes called an FSA ID. Nobody creates one on a parent's behalf and nobody shares credentials, including with us.
- **The identity check now clears immediately.** An account holder with a Social Security number is matched with the Social Security Administration in real time, which replaced the old wait of one to three business days. An unverified account has limited access until the check clears.
- **Every contributor gives consent and approval for the IRS transfer**, including a contributor who did not file, who filed taxes outside the United States, or who has no Social Security number. Entering the tax figures by hand is not a substitute.

Divorced or separated parents.

One parent files, and it is not automatically the parent the student lives with. The FAFSA parent is the one who provided **more than half** of the student's financial support over the last twelve months, and child support or alimony paid counts toward the payer's side of that calculation. If neither parent provided more than half, the parent with the greater income and assets files. Either way, if that parent has remarried, the new spouse is usually a required contributor too, which surprises families every year.

FOR IMMIGRANT FAMILIES A parent's immigration status is not part of the student's federal aid eligibility, and the FAFSA does not ask about it. A parent without a Social Security number can still create a StudentAid.gov account, be a contributor, and complete their section of the form.

The deadline that actually binds.

The federal deadline sits at the far end of the aid year. Every college sets its own, and those come first: an early-round applicant is usually filing in November. File in October and the question never comes up.

THREE / THE OTHER FORMS

The Profile, IDOC, and the March 2 *deadline.*

The FAFSA opens the federal door. Two more forms open the rest, and one carries a California date that no amount of good intent will move.

The CSS Profile.

The CSS Profile is College Board's application for non-federal institutional aid, meaning the money that comes out of a college's own budget. It opens October 1 each year and asks more than the FAFSA does: home equity, small business value, and at many colleges the finances of a noncustodial parent, who files a separate application under their own College Board account.

Not every college uses it. Check College Board's list of participating institutions, then check each college's own financial aid page, which is the authority on what it requires and when.

WORKED EXAMPLE · TWO COLLEGES, TWO CALENDARS

USC publishes its dates for the 2027–28 academic year outright: Early Decision aid is due November 1, 2026, Early Action November 15, 2026, and Regular Decision February 3, 2027. Boston University wants the CSS Profile and the FAFSA together on November 1 for Early Decision and January 5 for Early Decision II and regular admission, without naming a year on the page. Aid deadlines are often not the application deadlines, no two colleges share one, and a date printed without a year is worth confirming.

The fee is **\$25** for the first application and one college, then **\$16** for each additional college. It is free for a student whose family adjusted gross income is up to \$100,000, who qualified for an SAT fee waiver, or who is an orphan or ward of the court under 24. The waiver covers every application and reporting fee, and a noncustodial parent under that same \$100,000 files free too.

IDOC.

Not every student will use IDOC, and nobody starts it on their own. If a college needs the actual paperwork, College Board emails the student. The family uploads tax returns, W-2s, and whatever else was requested in one place, and College Board delivers them to every college on the list. Deadlines appear on the IDOC dashboard after sign-in, and they belong on the family calendar the day they appear.

California: the Cal Grant.

Cal Grant is California's own grant program, and its priority deadline of **March 2, 2027** needs two things in hand: a FAFSA (or a California Dream Act Application), and a verified high school GPA on file with the California Student Aid Commission. Most California high schools submit that GPA electronically and automatically, but confirming yours actually did it is the student's job, and it takes five minutes in a WebGrants 4 Students account. If a school cannot submit electronically, the paper form (G-4) has to be emailed or postmarked by the same date. The University of California states the window on its own site: file the 2027–28 FAFSA or California Dream Act Application between October 1, 2026 and March 2, 2027.

OUTSIDE CALIFORNIA Your state runs its own grant program, with its own form and its own deadline, and several award until the money runs out. Look up your state's agency in October, not February.

FOUR / THE CALENDAR

Everything due between now and *May 1.*

The dates in red are set by somebody other than a college. The rest belong to individual schools, so confirm each one on the school's own aid page and put it on the same calendar as the application deadlines.

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENS
This month	Create StudentAid.gov accounts for the student and every parent contributor. Gather the documents listed below. Early access to the form is open by request at StudentAid.gov/joinbeta.
October 1, 2026	The 2027–28 FAFSA opens to everyone. The CSS Profile for fall 2027 opens the same day.
Early November	Early Decision and Early Action aid deadlines at many colleges. The CSS Profile and the FAFSA are usually both due.
December	Early decisions arrive. An Early Decision admit's aid offer normally arrives with the admission.
January	Early Decision II and Regular Decision aid deadlines at most colleges.
February	IDOC requests arrive by email if a college needs documents. Aid offices begin building offers.
March 2, 2027	Cal Grant priority deadline: FAFSA or California Dream Act Application submitted, and a verified GPA on file with the California Student Aid Commission.
Late March, April	Regular decisions and their aid offers arrive.
April	Compare offers on net price. Send any appeal, with documentation, as soon as the reason for it is clear.
May 1, 2027	Most colleges want the enrollment deposit. Confirm the date on the admission letter, since a few differ.

What to gather this week.

- **The 2025 federal tax return** for every parent who will be a contributor, including a noncustodial parent who will file a separate CSS Profile.
- **2025 W-2s and any 1099s**, plus records of untaxed income: child support received, untaxed portions of pensions and IRA distributions, and contributions made to a retirement plan.
- **Current balances** for checking, savings, and any non-retirement investment or 529 accounts, plus the value of real estate other than the family home.
- **StudentAid.gov usernames** for the student and each parent contributor, written down somewhere both parents can find them in January.
- **The college list**, with each school's federal school code and its own aid deadline written beside it.

— FIVE / THE NUMBERS

What a year costs, and what an offer really *says*.

Two things decide most of this. One tells a family roughly what a college will cost before anyone applies. The other is the letter that arrives in the spring, and it is written to look better than it is.

Net price calculators.

Every college that participates in federal student aid posts a net price calculator on its own website. Twenty minutes with the 2025 tax return produces an estimate of what that specific college would charge this specific family, which is a far more useful number than the sticker price on the tuition page. Run one for every school under consideration while the list is still being built, not after the offers arrive.

Two cautions. The estimate is only as good as the numbers entered, and a calculator at a college that uses the CSS Profile will ask more questions than one that does not. And a calculator estimates need-based aid only, so it will not predict a merit scholarship.

Reading an aid offer.

Sort every line into three buckets before looking at any total. Money you keep: grants and scholarships. Money you earn: Federal Work-Study, which arrives as a paycheck for hours actually worked and never as a credit against the bill. Money you repay: anything with the word loan in it.

Then do the arithmetic the letter usually leaves out. Take the cost of attendance, subtract only the grants and scholarships, and what remains is what the year costs this family. Compare that number across colleges, and compare nothing else.

LINES THAT ARE QUIETLY A LOAN

- **Federal Direct Subsidized and Unsubsidized Loans.** A first-year dependent student can borrow up to \$5,500, of which at most \$3,500 is subsidized. Printed among the awards, it reads like aid.
- **Federal Direct PLUS Loan, or Parent PLUS.** Often listed at whatever amount closes the gap, which makes the bottom line appear to be zero.
- **Any figure labeled *total aid* or *your package*** that adds grants, work-study, and loans into a single number.
- **A letter with no line at all** for the balance the family still owes. That number always exists, and sometimes the family has to work it out.

Appeals.

An aid offer is not final. If the family's circumstances have changed since the 2025 tax year, through a lost job, reduced income, unusual medical costs, or a second child starting college, write to the aid office, say what changed, attach documentation, and ask for a review. Colleges call this a special circumstances review, every aid office has a process for it, and the answer is sometimes yes.

SIX / MERIT AND INTERNATIONAL AID

Two tracks that do not run on *need*.

Most of this guide is about need, which is a calculation. The two situations below are decided differently, and both of them turn on research that has to happen before an application goes in, not after.

Merit scholarships.

A merit scholarship is awarded for the strength of the application rather than the family's finances, and it comes out of the same college budget the need-based grants come from. At most colleges the admission application is the scholarship application, so there is nothing extra to file. The complication is timing.

Some colleges consider a student for merit only if the application arrives by a scholarship deadline earlier than the regular one, and some require an Early Action application specifically. Those dates are published on the college's own admission or financial aid page rather than in the Common App, so each one has to be looked up school by school.

WORKED EXAMPLE · TWO WAYS THIS SHOWS UP

Boston University states that for its Presidential Scholarship, the only requirement is to complete the application for admission by December 1. There is no scholarship form. There is only that date, and it comes a month ahead of the January dates on BU's own aid calendar.

USC runs merit through the Office of Admission on a track entirely separate from need: a student does not submit a need-based aid application to be considered for a USC Merit Scholarship, and the merit deadlines are the admission deadlines, which for most majors are November 1 for Early Decision and Early Action and January 10 for Regular Decision.

Not every college offers merit aid, and the ones that do differ enormously in how much. Before a school goes on the final list, read its financial aid page for the word scholarship and write down whatever deadline is attached to it.

International students.

The FAFSA is an application for federal aid, and a student who is neither a U.S. citizen nor an eligible noncitizen is not eligible for it. That rule is about the student, not the parents. A U.S. citizen whose parents are not citizens files the FAFSA in the ordinary way, and the form never asks about a parent's status.

For a genuinely international applicant the money is institutional. Many colleges do award their own aid to international students, and the CSS Profile is built to serve them: a family enters income and assets in its home currency and College Board converts them. Harvard's own instructions for the 2027–2028 school year state the split directly: every applicant regardless of citizenship submits a CSS Profile and an IDOC packet, and only U.S. citizens, permanent residents, and other eligible non-citizens also file the FAFSA. Some colleges use their own international aid form instead of the Profile, so read each college's page rather than assuming.

One question belongs in the research before any application is submitted: does this college take an international applicant's request for aid into account when it makes the admission decision? Colleges answer that differently, and the answer changes which schools belong on the list at all.

WORKING WITH US

Plans, deadlines, and a second pair of *eyes*.

We build the college list with each school's aid picture and its scholarship deadlines on it from the beginning. We put every aid date on the same calendar as the application dates. And when the offers arrive in the spring, we read them with you line by line and work out what each year actually costs. We do not file the FAFSA, the CSS Profile, or any aid form on a family's behalf, and nobody can promise an amount of aid before a college *decides it*.

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